(ii) Alternatively, an amendment can be proposed by a constitutional convention called by the Congress on the petition of two-thirds (34 out of 50) of the state legislatures. It should be ratified by the convention in three-fourths (38 out of 50) of state legislatures.

Hence, the procedure prescribed by the American Constitution for its amendment is very difficult, complicated and slow. Its rigid character is evident from the fact that it has been amended only 27 times since its promulgation in 1789.

3. Federal Constitution USA is a federal state. In fact, the USA is the first and the oldest federal state in the modern world. It is a federal republic comprising 50 states (originally 13 states) and the District of Columbia. The Constitution provides for division of powers between the Federal (Central) Government and the State Governments. It confers limited and specified powers on the Centre and vests the residuary powers (which are not enumerated in the Constitution) in the States. Each state has its own Constitution, elected legislature, governor and Supreme Court.

4. Presidential Government Unlike the British Constitution, the American Constitution provides for the Presidential form of Government. The features of the American Presidential system of Government are as follows:

(i) The American President is both, the head of State and the head of Government. As the head of State, he/she occupies a ceremonial position. As the head of Government, he/she leads the executive organ of Government. The President of the USA is the chief real executive.

(ii) The President is elected by an electoral college for a fixed tenure of four years. He/she cannot be removed by the Congress except by impeachment for a grave unconstitutional act.

(iii) The President governs with the help of the Cabinet or a smaller body called 'Kitchen' Cabinet. It is only an advisory body and consists of non-elected departmental secretaries. They are selected and appointed by him/her and are responsible only to him/her. They can also be removed by him/her any time.

(iv) The President and his/her Secretaries are not responsible to the Congress for their acts. They neither possess membership in the Congress nor attend its sessions.

(v) The President cannot dissolve the House of Representatives – the lower House of the Congress.

5. Separation of Powers The doctrine of separation of powers is the basis of the American constitutional system. The legislative, executive and judicial powers of the Government are separated and vested in the three independent organs of the Government. The first three articles of the Constitution clearly manifest this feature of the Constitution. Article I says that all legislative powers herein granted shall be vested in the Congress. Article II states that the executive powers shall be vested in the President. Article III provides that the judicial powers shall be vested in one Supreme Court and in such inferior courts as the Congress may from time to time ordain and establish.

6. Checks and Balances The system of checks and balances in the American Constitution is an outcome of the adoption of the principle of separation of powers. It enables each organ of the Government to exercise partial control on others so that no organ becomes autocratic and irresponsible. This means that no organ of Government has unrestricted powers even in its own sphere.